

The Whisper Cycle

Tales of the Threshold, from the Dhaharan Roads

Told by a Tulkani fire at the edge of the Satrapies

Set down by Dusana of the Raven Road

Under the lamp, bread and salt — and a whisper that the mountains cannot silence

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Preface: The Whisper That Walks

A cycle of stories is a cycle of hope. Some hope is written in ink. Some is written in blood. And some — the most dangerous kind — is written in a whisper that passes from mouth to mouth, quiet as a held breath.

My people are the Tulkani. We build no temples. We carry the hearth. But we also carry something else: a cult older than the roads we walk. The Tulkani whisper Ikasha's name. She who sleeps. She who waits. She who dreams of freedom.

In the north, the Aeler and the Kahfagians call it sedition. In the south, the Veiled Sisters call it heresy. But in the hills and the jungles and the monsoon ports, the people call it hope.

Dhahara is not one land. It is a braid of lands, pulled tight by empires. The northern **Aeler** came as conquerors and stayed as viceroys, building fire-shrines and elephant stables, their courts a blend of mountain stone and Dhaharan silk. They call themselves the Mountain Satrapies, and they answer to a High King beneath the peaks — but High Kings are distant, and tax collectors are not.

In the west, the followers of **Mykkiel** have raised temples of pale stone, their judges speaking the unyielding law of the Covenant. They do not conquer with swords. They conquer with contracts. The land there, once Dhaharan, now answers to a different bell.

The east belongs to the monsoon — to the spice ships of **Taharka**, the walking cities of **Ngomebe**, the honey groves of **Sekogo**, and the silk bridges of the **Lethai-ar**. They trade with Dhahara but do not rule it. Their merchants are guests, not masters. They count the cups and never pour the ninth.

And the small people — the **Aelinnel** in their bell-towers, the **Aelaerem** in their hollow hills — have lived here since before the first Aeler viceroy stepped off the mountain. They remember a Dhahara that was not split. They remember when the river had one name.

I walked this land for three winters. I carried Ikasha's whisper. I told stories in the tea-houses of Sarvistan, in the rope-yards of Port Shed, in the elephant stables of the Satrapies, and in the hidden groves where the Lethai-ar tie their silk cords.

This cycle is not the whisper. The whisper cannot be written. But these are the stories that make the whisper possible.

The ink is lamp-black. The fire is borrowed. The road is south. And Ikasha stirs in her sleep.

*At the base of the Himadri passes, with a sack of tea and a handful of salt. The ninth cup is for the dreamer.
— Dusana of the Raven Road*

1 The First Night: The Viceroy's Elephant

Told by

An old Aeler tunnel-wright who had served three viceroys and lost two fingers to a keystone. He spoke in a whisper, even though we were alone.

The Tale

The Aeler came to Dhahara on the backs of elephants. Not war elephants — those came later. The first elephants were surveyors, carrying stone-cutters and record-books up the passes. The Aeler measured the mountains. Then they measured the people.

A Dhaharan prince — call him Vikram — watched the viceroy's elephant trample his father's rice paddy. He did not speak. He walked to the viceroy's court and knelt.

"My father's paddy is ruined. The elephant carries a weight against us."

The viceroy laughed. "The elephant carries nothing. It is an animal. You carry a weight for grazing on its path."

Vikram stood. "Then I will bear that weight. But the elephant must first bear its own. A burden is a burden."

The viceroy was curious. He agreed. The elephant would be weighed against a single grain of wheat. If the wheat was heavier, the elephant would trample another field. If the elephant was heavier, Vikram would be given a year's grain.

They brought the scales. They placed the elephant on one side. They placed a single grain of wheat on the other.

The elephant was heavier.

Vikram smiled. "The weight is lifted."

The viceroy was furious. "You tricked me."

"I did not," Vikram said. "The scale is honest. The elephant weighs more than a grain. You did not ask what the elephant weighed against. You asked to weigh the elephant against a grain."

The viceroy paid. Vikram became a folk hero. He never challenged the viceroy again. But every time an Aeler elephant trampled a field, the farmers would whisper, "Weigh it against a grain."

The elephant never won again.

The Witch's Closing

"An agreement is a scale. If you choose the wrong weight, you will always lose. Choose carefully. The Aeler do."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Viceroy's Scales — A set of weigh-house scales that can be used to settle any dispute, provided both parties agree on the terms. But the terms are always chosen by the one who holds the grain.

Tags / Mechanics:

- The scales can resolve a dispute between two parties. Each party names a weight (an object, a promise, a memory). The scales determine which is heavier. The result is binding.
- A character may cheat by choosing a weight that is symbolic rather than literal (e.g., "a grain of truth"). The GM decides if the cheat works.
- **Clock: The Viceroy's Patience [6]** – ticks each time the scales are used to defy an Aeler official. When full, the viceroy sends a tax collector to audit the user's entire community.

Adventure Hook: A Dhaharan village has been using the viceroy's scales to cheat on taxes. The viceroy has noticed. He has sent an auditor — and a squad of elephant cavalry. The party must find a way to settle the dispute before the elephants trample the village.

2 The Second Night: The Judge of the Western Gate (Mykkiel)

Told by

A Pereshi merchant who had crossed the western passes three times. He spoke with a scar on his lip where a seal had bitten him.

The Tale

Mykkiel came to Dhahara with the Aeler, but he did not stay in the mountains. He walked west, to the dry lands where the river runs thin. His followers built courts of white stone. They did not preach. They judged.

A farmer — call her Zara — owed a weight to a Mykkielan templar. She had taken silver to buy a plow. The plow broke. The crop failed. The weight grew.

The templar came to her door. "You carry one hundred silver pieces."

"I have no silver," Zara said. "I have a goat."

"A goat is worth five silver."

"Then take twenty goats. I have three."

The templar was silent. Then he said, "The Covenant allows for substitution. But the value must be equal. A goat is not equal to silver."

Zara said, "Then take my name."

The templar frowned. "Your name has no value."

"It has value to me," Zara said. "And to my children. And to the land. Take my name, and the weight is gone."

The templar refused. He could not take a name — the Covenant had no clause for names. He left. Zara told her neighbors. They began offering names instead of silver. The templars were confused. They could not collect names. The system of weights collapsed.

Mykkiel himself appeared in a dream. "You have found a gap," he said. "I will close it."

But Zara was already dead. She had died of old age, her name still uncollected. The templars built a shrine to her — the Saint of the Unsettled Name. They still argue about whether she won.

The Witch's Closing

"The law is a wall. A name is a door. The wall has no door, but the wall cannot close what it does not see."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Unsettled Name — A legal gap in the Mykkielan Covenant. Names cannot be taken as payment unless the bearer offers them freely. Once offered, the name becomes property of the creditor — but the bearer may still use it.

Tags / Mechanics:

- A character who offers their name to settle a weight may still use their name freely. The creditor cannot prevent them. But the creditor can use the name in legal documents, causing confusion.
- If the character later dies, the creditor gains ownership of the name permanently. The character's descendants must use a different surname for legal purposes.
- **Clock: The Covenant's Amendment [8]** – ticks each time a name is used to settle a weight. When full, Mykkiel closes the gap. All outstanding name-weights are converted to silver at a punishing rate.

Adventure Hook: A Mykkielan templar is trying to collect a weight from a dead woman. Her family refuses to pay. The templar has seized their names. The party must find a way to free the names — or convince the temple that the weight was already lifted.

3 The Third Night: The Monsoon's Daughter (Taharka, Ngomebe, Ayokha)

Told by

A Taharkan spice merchant who had sailed from the Monsoon Coast to the Inland Sea and back again. She smelled of cardamom and salt.

The Tale

The monsoon is not a wind. It is a woman. She has three daughters: one who brings rain to Taharka, one who brings grain to Ngomebe, and one who brings ships to Ayokha.

The eldest daughter — call her Rani — fell in love with a Dhaharan sailor. She followed his ship across the sea. The rain stopped in Taharka. The crops failed. The king sent a messenger.

"Return, daughter. Your people need you."

Rani refused. "The sailor needs me more."

The messenger returned to the king. The king consulted the spirits. They said, "A trade. One monsoon for one story. If the story is good, the daughter returns."

The king did not know any stories. He sent a Tulkani storyteller instead.

The storyteller sat on the shore and told a tale of a woman who loved a sailor and drowned. The sea was her grave. The monsoon was her tears.

Rani heard the tale. She wept. The sailor did not drown — but the story made her feel his drowning. She returned to Taharka. The rains started again.

The king asked the storyteller, "What did you tell her?"

"The truth," the storyteller said. "A truth she had not yet lived. Sometimes that is enough."

The Witch's Closing

"The monsoon is a story. Tell it right, and it will rain. Tell it wrong, and the ships will wait."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Monsoon's Daughter — A spirit of the rains. She can be persuaded to bring or withhold rain by the telling of a story. The story must be true — not necessarily factual, but emotionally true.

Tags / Mechanics:

- A character who knows a story that moves the Monsoon's Daughter may roll *Spirit + Performance* (DV 5). On success, the rains come within 1d4 days. On failure, the rains delay for another week.

- The story can be about any subject, but it must be new to the Daughter. She has heard most tales; the storyteller must improvise.
- **Clock: The Monsoon's Patience [8]** – ticks each time a story fails to move her. When full, the Daughter returns to her mother and does not speak to mortals for a generation.

Adventure Hook: The monsoon has failed. The spice fleet is stranded. The king has offered a fortune to anyone who can bring the rains. The party knows a story — but will it be enough?

4 The Fourth Night: The Aelinnel Bell and the Aelaerem Cup

Told by

Two voices: an Aelinnel bell-tender named Greta and an Aelaerem hedge-witch named Thistle. They told the tale together, interrupting each other, finishing each other's sentences.

The Tale

Aelinnel and Aelaerem have lived in Dhahara since before the hills had names. The Aelinnel count steps. The Aelaerem pour cups. They agree on very little.

A famine came. The Aelinnel bell-tender rang her bell eight times. The Hollow did not answer. The hedge-witch poured eight cups. The Hollow did not drink.

"The Hollow is full," the witch said.

"The Hollow is deaf," the bell-tender said.

They argued. A child — neither gnome nor halfling, but something in between — spoke up.

"Why do you need the Hollow? Why not speak to each other?"

The bell-tender and the hedge-witch looked at each other. They had never tried.

The bell-tender rang the bell for the witch. The witch poured a cup for the bell-tender. They shared the cup. The bell echoed.

The Hollow did not stir. But the famine ended. The rains came. The Aelinnel and the Aelaerem did not become friends — but they became neighbors. And sometimes, that is enough.

The Witch's Closing

"The Hollow is not the only listener. Sometimes the person next to you is enough."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Shared Threshold — A place where Aelinnel and Aelaerem customs meet. A bell and a cup sit side by side. Those who use both receive a blessing; those who use neither are ignored.

Tags / Mechanics:

- A character who rings the bell and pours the cup gains +2 dice on their next roll (the blessing of two peoples).
- A character who uses only one custom gains no benefit — the threshold does not recognize partial effort.
- **Clock: The Hollow's Curiosity [6]** — ticks each time the bell and cup are used together. When full, the Hollow sends a messenger. The messenger offers a bargain — one wish, one price.

Adventure Hook: An Aelinnel village and an Aelaerem village share a well. The well has run dry. The only way to restore it is for the two peoples to perform a joint ritual — but they cannot agree on whether to ring the bell first or pour the cup first.

5 The Fifth Night: The Lethai-ar's Silk Bridge

Told by

A Lethai-ar silk-weaver who lived in the Crimson Valley. She spoke through a curtain of red thread, her voice soft as running water.

The Tale

The Lethai-ar do not build bridges of stone. Stone cracks. They build bridges of silk. Silk bends. Silk remembers.

A Dhaharan prince — call him Arjun — needed to cross a gorge. The Aeler viceroy had sealed the mountain pass. The only other route was a Lethai-ar silk bridge, strung between two cliffs.

The Lethai-ar agreed to let him cross — for a price. "Give us your name."

Arjun laughed. "My name is worthless."

"Your name is a thread," the weaver said. "We will weave it into the bridge. When you cross, the bridge will know you."

Arjun gave his name. He crossed. The bridge held. He returned to his kingdom.

Years later, the Aeler viceroy attacked. Arjun's army was outnumbered. He returned to the Lethai-ar.

"Let me cross again."

The weaver shook her head. "Your name is already in the bridge. You do not need to pay again. But the bridge has been waiting for you. It will not hold for anyone else."

Arjun led his army across. The bridge swayed. The silk sang. The Aeler pursuers tried to follow. The bridge dropped them into the gorge.

Arjun won his kingdom. He never gave his name to anyone again. But he visited the Lethai-ar every year, and he always brought silk.

The Witch's Closing

"A name woven into silk is a promise. The silk remembers. The bridge holds — or it does not."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Silk Bridge — A Lethai-ar bridge that records the names of those who cross. A named person may cross freely; a stranger must pay a toll. The bridge judges the weight of the name, not the coin.

Tags / Mechanics:

- A character whose name is woven into the bridge may cross at any time without toll.
- A character who gives a false name triggers the bridge's trap: the silk wraps around them, immobilizing them until they speak their true name.
- **Clock: The Bridge's Memory [8]** – ticks each time a false name is given. When full, the bridge begins to fray.

It can still be crossed, but each crossing costs 1 Fatigue (the silk pulls at the traveler's memory).

Adventure Hook: A Lethai-ar silk bridge has begun to sag. The weaver is dead. The names in the bridge are fading. The party must find a way to re-weave the bridge — or cross before it collapses.

6 The Sixth Night: The Viceroy's Dream (Ikasha)

Told by

A Tulkani storyteller — myself — at a fire in the Himadri foothills. The audience was a group of Aeler miners who had not heard Ikasha's name before.

The Tale

Ikasha sleeps. She has slept for a thousand years. But she dreams. And in her dreams, she whispers.

A miner — call him Durin — worked in the deep galleries. He was tired. He was cold. He was afraid of the dark.

One night, he fell asleep at his post. He dreamed of a woman with black hair and blacker eyes. She sat in a stone chair, her hands folded in her lap.

"You are afraid," she said.

"Yes," Durin said.

"Of the dark?"

"Of the dark. Of the stone. Of the mountain falling."

She nodded. "I am the dark. I am the stone. I am the mountain. You are not afraid of me. You are afraid of what I might do."

Durin was silent.

"I will not do anything," she said. "I sleep. I dream. I whisper. That is all."

"What do you whisper?"

"The truth. That the mountain is not your master. That the viceroy is not your king. That you are awake — and I am not."

Durin woke. He told the other miners. They began to whisper her name. The viceroy heard. He sent a priest to investigate.

The priest found the miners whispering in the dark. He asked, "What are you whispering?"

"The name of the dreamer," they said.

The priest left. He did not report them. He whispered Ikasha's name that night in his own bed.

The viceroy never found out. But the mines grew quieter. The miners worked slower. They were not afraid anymore. They were waiting.

The Witch's Closing

"Ikasha does not command. She whispers. A whisper is not a rebellion. It is the seed of one."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Whisper of Ikasha — A current that spreads through dreams. Those who hear Ikasha's whisper gain +1 die to resist fear, but they become more visible to the viceroy's spies.

Tags / Mechanics:

- A character who whispers Ikasha's name before sleeping gains +1 die to resist fear for the next day.
- Each time a character uses this benefit, they mark 1 Exposure (the viceroy's network may notice).
- **Clock: The Viceroy's Attention [6]** – ticks each time a character uses Ikasha's whisper in a public place. When full, the viceroy sends an auditor to interrogate the character's community.

Adventure Hook: The viceroy has heard rumors of the whisper. He has sent a censor to the mining camps. The party must protect those who carry the whisper — or use the whisper to turn the censor against his master.

7 The Seventh Night: The Minister Who Left No Gift

Told by

A Tulkani storyteller who had walked the length of the Brass Coast. She would not give her name. "I am the one who carries this tale," she said. "That is enough."

The Tale

The Lethai-al do not raise children. They raise trees. But every few generations, a child is born who does not belong to the forest — and the forest watches her anyway.

A Kahfagian girl — call her Nia — was born in a trade post at the edge of the Crimson Valley. Her father was a dock-master; her mother died of a fever before Nia could speak. The Lethai-al of the valley had no quarrel with the child. But they had a treaty with the old forest: guard the innocent, regardless of their blood.

So a sentinel came. The girl never saw her face. She saw only signs: a feather left on the windowsill, a stone that was not there the night before, a knot in a piece of rope that had been straight an hour ago.

When Nia was five, she found a polished river stone on her pillow. She kept it under her tongue until her father noticed and made her spit it out.

When she was ten, she left her first gift in return: a button from her coat, placed on the doorstep. The next morning, the button was gone. In its place, a single green leaf, folded into a bird.

She tried to speak to the sentinel. "Who are you?"

The answer came not in words, but in a pattern of pebbles on the path: a question mark that was also a spiral.

"Why do you watch me?"

A circle of salt around the well. Then a line through the circle, pointing east. *Because you are here*, it seemed to say. *And the east is where the mist begins.*

As she grew, her gifts matured. A broken necklace. A silver coin from her first wage. A letter she had written and then decided not to send. Each time, the sentinel answered with something stranger: a feather that could write by itself for one hour, a thimble that never lost its thread, a dried flower that smelled of rain in the desert.

Nia became a minister in the colonial administration. She did not seek the post; it was offered, and she was good at it. She spoke three languages. She could read a contract and find the hidden clause. She could look a Dhaharan farmer in the eye and tell him that his land was needed for a new rope-walk, and she could do it without flinching.

She told herself she was helping. She moved families to better plots. She negotiated water rights. She reduced the tariff on millet by a fraction of a percent — enough to save lives, she believed. She did not see the people who disappeared. She did not see the whippings. She did not see the children taken to the Ashaani coast.

Her gifts to the sentinel stopped. She had nothing to give that would not be a bribe.

The sentinel waited. A month. A year. Two years.

One night, Nia woke to find a single object on her desk: a Sari, folded so tightly it was the size of a fist. She had never seen it before, but she knew it was from the forest.

She unfolded it. It was white. There were no patterns — only a single thread of red running through the hem.

She whispered, "I have nothing to give."

A voice — the first voice she had ever heard from the sentinel — spoke from the shadow of the curtain. "You have your blood. That is not nothing."

Nia laughed, but it was a hollow sound. "My blood is Kahfagian. You know that."

"Home is not a matter of blood," the sentinel said. "You have lived in this valley for thirty years. The trees know your step. The well knows your cup. The only thing that does not know you is your own record."

Nia was silent.

"Why do you attack your home?" the sentinel asked.

"I am not attacking. I am administering. There is a difference."

"Is there? The surveyors who came last week — they drew a line through the grove where my mother is buried. They did not ask. They measured. That is a kind of attack."

Nia opened her mouth to argue. But she had drawn the line herself. She had signed the survey. She had told herself it was for the rope-walk, which would bring jobs, which would feed families.

She had not asked about the grove.

"I have no choice," she whispered.

"You have the same choice you have always had," the sentinel said. "You can give a gift. Or you can take one."

The sentinel left. Nia sat at her desk until dawn. She did not cry. She wrote her resignation. She did not send it.

She folded the Sari into a fist and put it in her pocket.

Three days later, she disappeared. The colonial administration searched. They found her desk, her records, her seal. They did not find her.

Some say she walked into the jungle and the Lethai-al took her in. Others say she drowned in the monsoon river. A few — very few — whisper that she became the sentinel's replacement, watching the next child of empire, waiting to ask the same question.

The Sari was never found.

The Witch's Closing

"A gift given is a thread. A gift taken is a cut. The sentinel waits. The minister fled. The forest does not judge. It remembers."

What Lurks in the Shadow of the Tale

The Sentinel's Thread — A Lethai-al tradition of watching over a child of empire, not to convert them, but to offer them a chance to see. The sentinel leaves symbolic gifts. The child's gifts in return are a conversation. If the child stops giving, the sentinel may eventually speak. And what they say is never kind.

Tags / Mechanics:

- A character who was protected by a sentinel as a child gains +1 die to resist fear when in familiar jungle terrain.
- If the character has since participated in colonial violence, they may seek out the sentinel again. On a successful *Spirit + Lore* test (DV 5), the sentinel appears and asks one question. The answer must be truthful, or the sentinel leaves forever.
- The Sari of the Minister is said to grant the wearer +1 die to any roll made to hide or escape. But if the wearer has ever signed a colonial survey, the fabric feels heavy — a constant reminder.
- **Clock: The Forest's Patience [8]** — ticks each time a character chooses administration over justice. When full, the sentinel appears, and the character must make a choice: abandon their post or abandon the forest.

Adventure Hook: A colonial minister has disappeared. Her Sari is found hanging in a Lethai-al grove. The Admiralty wants it back. The party must decide: return the Sari and face the minister's fate, or leave it — and risk being watched.

Epilogue: The Road Ahead

I have told seven tales. The viceroy's auditor has not come. The whisper spreads.

Dhahara is not one land. It is a dream that has not yet woken. The Aeler sit in their mountain courts, counting taxes and weighing grain. The Mykkielan judges rewrite their contracts, closing gaps that names can slip through. The monsoon ships arrive on time, carrying spices and silk and the quiet stories of other lands.

And the Tulkani walk the roads, carrying the hearth and the whisper.

I do not know when Ikasha will wake. I do not know if the viceroy will fall. I do not know if the bridges will hold.

But the stories are being told. That is enough for now.

On the road south, with a new notebook and an old whisper. The ninth cup is for the dreamer. The ninth tale is for the road.

— Dusana of the Raven Road

Appendix: Customs of the Dhaharan Roads

Custom	Culture	Consequence of Breaking
Weigh an elephant against a grain of wheat.	Dhaharan (folk)	The elephant may refuse to move.
Offer a name instead of silver.	Mykkielan (western)	The name becomes property of the court.
Tell a true story to bring the rains.	Monsoon peoples	The story may not be sufficient.
Ring the bell and pour the cup together.	Aelinnel & Aelaerem	The Hollow notices.
Weave a name into silk to cross a bridge.	Lethai-ar (Crimson Valley)	The bridge may forget you.
Whisper Ikasha's name before sleep.	Tulkani & miners	The viceroy's spies may hear.
Give a gift to a sentinel.	Lethai-al (forest)	The sentinel may speak. Not speaking is the greater gift.

Colophon

This book was written on paper made from mulberry bark, in ink cut with lamp-black and the ash of a viceroy's seal. The binding is silk, tied with nine cords.

The ninth cord is not cut.

The whisper continues.

The road is south.

At the edge of the Crimson Basin, with a new notebook and an old lamp. The ink is fresh. The dreamer stirs.
— *Dusana of the Raven Road*